

The OTA Duopoly

A structural overview of the two American holding companies — Expedia Group and Booking Holdings — that together control the majority of online travel booking worldwide. This brief covers their history, ownership, brand portfolios, and the rate-parity contractual machinery that keeps prices nearly identical across both giants' platforms.

SUBJECT

Expedia Group (EXPE) & Booking Holdings (BKNG)

SCOPE

Ownership, subsidiaries, parity-clause mechanics

COMPILED

October 2026 · Z.ai Research

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CHAPTER 1 · OVERVIEW

Executive Summary: The OTA Duopoly

When you compare hotel prices across Expedia, Travelocity, Orbitz, Hotels.com, Booking.com, Priceline, and Agoda, you are almost always looking at the same two companies. The global online-travel booking market — outside China and a few regional players — is dominated by two American holding companies: **Expedia Group, Inc.** (Nasdaq: EXPE) and **Booking Holdings Inc.** (Nasdaq: BKNG). Each owns more than a dozen consumer travel brands, and together they control an estimated 70-80% of Western online travel agency (OTA) room-nights sold. This brief unpacks who owns what, how each giant is structured, and the contractual machinery — known as *rate parity clauses* — that keeps hotel prices nearly identical no matter which of their dozens of websites you happen to open.

Both companies were founded in 1996: Expedia as a Microsoft division led by Rich Barton, and Priceline (the predecessor of Booking Holdings) in Stamford, Connecticut, founded by Jay S. Walker on a "Name Your Own Price" bidding model. Today Expedia is headquartered in Seattle and led by chairman Barry Diller and CEO Ariane Gorin, while Booking Holdings is headquartered in Norwalk, Connecticut, led by CEO Glenn Fogel and chair Robert J. Mylod Jr. Combined, the two giants generated over **US\$41 billion in revenue** in fiscal 2025 and employ roughly 41,000 people worldwide.

The reason prices look identical across their brands is not coincidence or collusion in the legal sense — it is contract. For more than a decade, both Expedia and Booking have used **most-favored-nation (MFN) clauses**, also called *rate parity clauses*, in their agreements with hotels. These clauses require the hotel to offer the same publicly available room price across every OTA channel and, in their stricter "wide" form, even on the hotel's own website. Europe, France, Austria, Germany, Italy, and Belgium have all cracked down on these clauses since 2015; the U.S. and U.K. have not. The result is that where regulation is weak, the duopoly's pricing power is effectively absolute.

THE TWO GIANTS	Expedia Group (EXPE) + Booking Holdings (BKNG)
COMBINED 2025 REVENUE	US\$41.6 billion
COMBINED WORKFORCE	~40,800 employees
BRANDS JOINTLY CONTROLLED	25+ consumer travel brands
ROOT CAUSE OF PRICE SIMILARITY	Rate parity / MFN clauses in hotel contracts
WHERE PARITY IS REGULATED	EU, France, Germany, Austria, Italy, Belgium, Australia, India
WHERE PARITY IS UNREGULATED	USA, UK, Latin America

CHAPTER 2 · EXPEDIA GROUP

Expedia Group (Nasdaq: EXPE)

History & Corporate Lineage

Expedia was founded on October 22, 1996 as a division of Microsoft, the brainchild of Rich Barton, who saw an opportunity to bring the then-nascent World Wide Web to travel booking. In 1999 Microsoft spun Expedia out as a public company, the first of several ownership transitions the company would undergo. In 2001, IAC (then known as USA Networks Inc., controlled by media mogul Barry Diller) acquired a controlling interest in Expedia; IAC bought the remainder of the company in 2003. Two years later, in August 2005, IAC spun Expedia back out as a standalone public company — Expedia, Inc. — which is essentially the entity that exists today. In December 2011, Expedia spun off its TripAdvisor metasearch unit as a separate public company, exiting the meta-search business to focus on transactional OTAs. In 2019 the company relocated its headquarters from Bellevue, Washington to a new Seattle campus.

Recent strategic moves include the 2023 launch of **One Key**, a unified loyalty program spanning Expedia, Hotels.com, and Vrbo that allows travelers to earn and redeem rewards across all three. In 2024 the company rolled out **Travel Shops**, a creator-marketplace allowing influencers to earn commissions on hotel recommendations, and an AI-powered trip-planning assistant. The most recent material acquisition was Tiqets (December 2025), an activities-and-experiences ticketing platform. In February 2024 the company announced it would cut about 1,500 jobs, of which 208 were from the Seattle office, in a restructuring to refocus on technology and B2B partnerships.

Leadership & Ownership

The chairman and senior executive is **Barry Diller**, who has been the central strategic figure since IAC acquired control in 2001. He owns or controls approximately 15% of outstanding shares — the largest single individual stake, which gives him outsized voting influence despite the company's public listing. The current CEO is **Ariane Gorin** (Vice Chairman and CEO), who took over in 2024 after Rich Barton's second stint as CEO ended. Founder Rich Barton remains on the board. The largest institutional shareholders are **Vanguard Group** (~11% of outstanding shares), **BlackRock** (~9%), and **State Street Corporation** (~4-5%). Together these three passive index investors control roughly 25-30% of the float; they do not exercise operational control but vote on shareholder resolutions. Other institutional asset managers (Fidelity, T. Rowe Price, Geode Capital, etc.) hold much of the remainder.

Expedia Group (EXPE) — Approximate Shareholder Composition

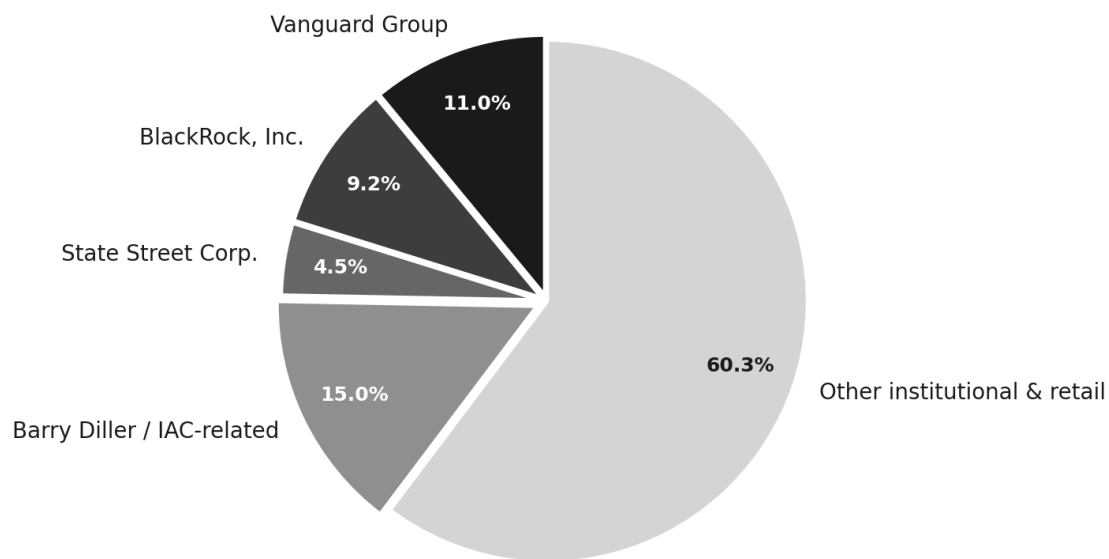


Figure 1. Approximate shareholder composition of Expedia Group. Vanguard, BlackRock, and State Street are passive index investors; their combined ~25% of the float does not confer operational control. Barry Diller's ~15% stake and IAC-legacy voting position give him effective strategic control. Percentages are approximate as of 2024-2025 SEC filings.

Brand Portfolio & Subsidiaries

Expedia Group operates 13 consumer travel brands plus two enterprise B2B divisions. The flagship is the eponymous **Expedia.com** full-service OTA, complemented by **Hotels.com** (hotel-focused), **Vrbo** (whole-home vacation rentals, the rebrand of HomeAway acquired in 2015 for \$3.9B), **Travelocity** (acquired 2015 for \$280M), **Orbitz** (acquired 2015 for \$1.6B), **Hotwire** (opaque-rate booking), **CheapTickets**, **Ebookers** (European OTA), **CarRentals.com**, **Wotif** (Australia/NZ, acquired 2014 for \$657M), and **Expedia Cruises** (a Vancouver-based travel-agency franchise network with ~260 North American locations). The newest addition is **Tiqets** (activities and experiences, December 2025).

The most structurally interesting asset is **Trivago N.V.**, the German hotel metasearch engine in which Expedia acquired a majority stake in 2012 for approximately €477 million in cash and stock. Trivago is itself listed on Nasdaq as TRVG; Expedia owns the controlling majority but does not own 100% of its equity. This is the only major "controlled through a publicly-traded proxy" structure in Expedia's portfolio. On the B2B side, **Expedia Group Media Solutions** is the advertising arm that sells sponsored placements and media products to travel suppliers, while **Expedia Group Partner Solutions** supplies Expedia's lodging inventory to third-party travel agencies, airlines, and loyalty programs via API and white-label integrations.

Material Acquisitions

The table below lists every material acquisition Expedia has made since 2000 with disclosed values. It illustrates the consolidation strategy: acquire regional OTAs (Wotif for Australia, Ebookers for Europe, Travelscape for Las Vegas), specialty verticals (HomeAway for vacation rentals, Trivago for metasearch, Tiqets for experiences), and corporate-travel agencies (Egencia, VIA Travel). Note that Egencia was subsequently sold to American Express Global Business Travel in November 2021, and Classic Vacations was divested to Najafi Companies in

March 2021 — Expedia has been pruning its corporate-travel and packaged-vacation footprint to refocus on consumer OTA inventory.

Mar 2000	Travelscape	Travel agency	~\$89.75M
Mar 2001	Vacationspot	Hotel booking engine	~\$70.85M
Mar 2002	Classic Custom Vacations	Travel agency	~\$78M
Oct 2002	Newtrade Technologies	Reservation software	Undisclosed
Apr 2004	Egencia	Corporate travel agency	Undisclosed
Jul 2008	Venere.com	Hotel booking engine	€200M
Oct 2010	Mobiata	Mobile app developer	Undisclosed
Dec 2012	trivago GmbH (majority)	Hotel metasearch	€477M (cash + stock)
Jul 2014	Wotif	Australian travel agency	\$657M
Jan 2015	Travelocity	Travel agency	\$280M
Sep 2015	Orbitz	Travel agency	\$1.6B
Nov 2015	HomeAway (→ Vrbo)	Vacation rentals	\$3.9B
Oct 2018	Pillow / ApartmentJet	Short-term rental mgmt	Undisclosed
Aug 2019	CanadaStays	Canadian vacation rentals	Undisclosed
Dec 2025	Tiqets	Activities & experiences	Undisclosed

Table 1. Expedia Group material acquisitions, 2000–2025.

CHAPTER 3 · BOOKING HOLDINGS

Booking Holdings (Nasdaq: BKNG)

History & Corporate Lineage

Booking Holdings was founded in 1996 in Stamford, Connecticut, by **Jay S. Walker** as Priceline.com Incorporated, launching the eponymous Priceline.com website on a "Name Your Own Price" bidding model — consumers named a price they were willing to pay for an airline ticket or hotel room, and Priceline matched them with a supplier willing to accept. Priceline went public on March 31, 1999 under ticker PCLN; the IPO turned Walker, who owned 35% of the company, into a multi-billionaire. The company experimented with groceries, gasoline, and mortgages but discontinued those lines in 2000 to refocus on travel. In 2005 it acquired Booking.com for \$133 million — widely regarded as one of the most profitable acquisitions of the 2000s. The corporate parent was renamed The Priceline Group Inc. in 2014 and finally **Booking Holdings** in February 2018, when the ticker changed to BKNG.

Booking Holdings is significantly larger than Expedia by revenue (\$26.9B vs \$14.7B in 2025) and has compounded profitably for two decades. Its headquarters is in Norwalk, Connecticut; the Booking.com operating subsidiary is headquartered in Amsterdam. CEO **Glenn D. Fogel** has held the role since January 2017, having previously served as head of strategy and corporate development. Chair **Robert J. Mylod Jr.** is a former vice chairman of Bank of America. Booking Holdings operates websites in approximately 40 languages and 200 countries; in 2023, consumers booked 1.235 billion room nights, 88 million rental-car days, and 68 million airplane tickets through its platforms.

Brand Portfolio & Subsidiaries

Booking Holdings operates 11 primary consumer brands plus a couple of B2B / hospitality SaaS subsidiaries. The flagship is **Booking.com**, the world's largest accommodation OTA by room-nights, with operations spanning nearly every country. **Priceline** retains the legacy name-your-own-price brand positioning in the U.S. market. **Agoda** is the Asia-Pacific specialist, headquartered in Bangkok, with particular strength in Thailand, Japan, and Southeast Asia. **Kayak** (acquired 2013 for \$1.8B) is the metasearch arm — comparable in function to Trivago but owned outright rather than as a partial stake. **Rentalcars.com** handles car rentals, while **Cheapflights** and **Momondo** (both acquired together in 2017 for \$550M) handle flight metasearch in European markets.

On the hospitality side, **OpenTable** (acquired 2014 for \$2.6B) is the dominant restaurant-reservation platform in North America — a vertical extension beyond travel into dining. **FareHarbor** (acquired 2018 for \$250M) provides reservation software to tour-and-activity operators. **HotelsCombined** (acquired 2018 for \$140M) is another metasearch asset, and **Getaroom** (acquired 2022 for \$1.2B) provides wholesale lodging distribution. In 2018 Booking Holdings also took a \$500M minority stake in Chinese ride-hailing company **DiDi**, its only material non-travel investment. Unlike Expedia, Booking Holdings does not have a partially-owned publicly-traded affiliate; all its subsidiaries are wholly owned.

Material Acquisitions

2004	Active Hotels (UK)	European hotel booking	\$161M
2005	Booking.com (NL)	European OTA — the future flagship	\$133M
2007	Agoda	Asia-Pacific OTA	Undisclosed
2010	TravelJigsaw / Rentalcars	Car rentals	Undisclosed
2013	Kayak	Metasearch	\$1.8B
2014	OpenTable	Restaurant reservations	\$2.6B
2014	Buuteeq + Hotel Ninjas	Hotel marketing SaaS	\$98M
2015	Rocketmiles	Loyalty air-miles hotel booking	Undisclosed
2017	Momondo + Cheapflights	Flight metasearch	\$550M
2018	FareHarbor	Tours & activities SaaS	\$250M
2018	HotelsCombined	Hotel metasearch	\$140M
2018	DiDi (minority)	Chinese ride-hailing	\$500M
2022	Getaroom	Wholesale lodging distribution	\$1.2B
2026	Libro (via OpenTable)	Canadian restaurant reservations	Undisclosed

Table 2. Booking Holdings material acquisitions, 2004–2026.

CHAPTER 4 · PRICING MECHANICS

Why the Prices Look the Same: Rate Parity Explained

The Mechanism: Most-Favored-Nation Clauses

When a hotel signs a distribution contract with Booking.com or Expedia, that contract almost always contains a **rate parity clause**, sometimes called a "best-price clause" or — in antitrust terminology — a "most-favored-nation" (MFN) clause. The clause requires the hotel to offer the same publicly available room price on every OTA channel, and in its stricter "wide" form, even on the hotel's own direct website. The economic effect is that you cannot find meaningfully lower hotel prices by shopping around across Expedia, Orbitz, Travelocity, Hotels.com, Booking.com, Priceline, or Agoda — because contractually they are all required to display the same number.

Parity clauses are not new. Pre-internet, large hotels followed the same practice across GDSs, travel agencies, walk-in, and direct phone reservations — parity was a way to prevent price wars and preserve brand consistency. What changed in the late 1990s and 2000s was the rise of OTAs, which aggressively dumped prices to grab market share. As Booking.com and Expedia consolidated control, they reversed the dynamic: they began demanding parity *from* the hotels as a contractual precondition for distribution. The OTAs invested heavily in advertising, captured an estimated 25-75% of all online bookings (depending on country and segment), and used that leverage to dictate pricing terms to their suppliers — even independent hotels that had no negotiating power.

Wide vs. Narrow Parity

There are two main flavors of parity clause, and the distinction matters legally:

Wide parity (the strictest form) requires the hotel to offer Booking.com / Expedia the best price available *anywhere*, including on the hotel's own direct website. The hotel cannot run a "10% off if you book direct" promotion. The hotel cannot offer a lower rate to a competing OTA. Every public channel must show the same number. This was the default clause structure used by both Expedia and Booking.com until approximately 2015.

Narrow parity (the softer form) relaxes the rule. The hotel may offer lower prices on other OTAs, via phone, via email, or to loyalty-program members — provided the price displayed on Booking.com or Expedia is not higher than the price on the hotel's own direct website. The crucial restriction is that those lower-rate offers must not surface in metasearch engines like Trivago, Kayak, Google Hotel Search, or TripAdvisor — because if a metasearch shows the cheaper price, the OTA's marketing spend is undermined. Narrow parity is the clause structure that prevails today in markets where regulators have intervened.

Why Hotels Agree to It

Parity benefits the OTAs, but it also benefits hotels in narrow ways: it ensures customer trust (a guest who finds a lower price on another platform after booking feels cheated), it simplifies tariff management (one price, one update, all channels), and it lets hotels compete on amenities and service rather than price wars. More importantly, for an independent hotel or small B&B, refusing to sign a parity clause means being delisted from

Booking.com or Expedia — and for many properties, that means losing access to the majority of online bookers. The contractual terms are take-it-or-leave-it, and most hotels take them. As a result, even in jurisdictions where wide parity is banned, hotels often continue to comply with effective parity in practice, because the alternative is a 30-50% drop in bookings.

The Regulatory Patchwork

There is no global rate-parity law. Each jurisdiction has moved independently, producing a patchwork:

European Union (EEA)	Banned wide parity 2015; Booking.com + Expedia moved to narrow parity EU-wide.
France, Austria, Germany, Italy, Belgium	Banned both wide AND narrow parity for all OTAs.
Germany, Sweden (specifically)	Ordered IHG, Booking.com, and Expedia to remove ALL parity clauses from hotel contracts.
Australia, New Zealand	Narrow parity only; wide parity prohibited.
India (2022)	Banned both parity AND exclusivity obligations for MakeMyTrip and Goibibo.
United States, UK, Latin America	Unregulated — wide parity clauses remain legal and standard.
DMA (Digital Markets Act, EU, 2024+)	Imposes additional obligations on OTAs designated as "gatekeepers."

Table 3. Rate-parity regulatory landscape by jurisdiction.

Notably, a 2020 European Commission study found **no significant change** in hotel pricing after the 2015 switch to narrow parity in the EU. Independent hotels — which constitute the majority of European supply outside the major chains — continue to comply with effective parity regardless of regulation, because they are structurally dependent on the duopoly for distribution. The clauses may be illegal on paper, but market power makes them de-facto.

OTA Loyalty Programs: Pricing Around Parity

Since direct price discounting is constrained by parity, both giants have built loyalty programs that effectively cut the consumer's net cost without violating the public-display rule. Booking Holdings operates **Booking.com Genius**, a tiered loyalty program that gives 10-15% discounts to repeat bookers — these discounts apply after booking confirmation, so they do not appear as the publicly displayed rate. Expedia Group launched **One Key** in 2023, unifying rewards across Expedia, Hotels.com, and Vrbo into a single earn-and-burn currency. The same trick applies: the publicly displayed room rate is identical across Expedia's brands (to satisfy parity), but the member earns "OneKeyCash" redeemable on future bookings, effectively lowering the net price only for repeat customers in the loyalty ecosystem. The result is that OTAs retain parity on paper while still competing on effective price — but only for travelers willing to commit to one ecosystem.

CHAPTER 5 · COMPARISON

Side-by-Side Brand Portfolio Comparison

The corporate structures of Expedia Group and Booking Holdings are remarkably parallel. Both started in 1996. Both are publicly traded on Nasdaq. Both control 10+ consumer travel brands. Both operate B2B / enterprise divisions. Both have a metasearch asset (Trivago for Expedia, Kayak for Booking). Both took a vacation-rental vertical (HomeAway/Vrbo for Expedia; Booking.com's vacation-rentals product for Booking). Both have invested in activities and experiences (Tiqets for Expedia; FareHarbor for Booking). The chart below maps the structure of both giants side-by-side.

The OTA Duopoly — Corporate Structure & Brand Portfolio

Both Expedia Group and Booking Holdings operate as publicly-traded holding companies controlling 10+ consumer travel brands each, plus B2B divisions and partially-owned affiliates. Trivago is majority-controlled by Expedia; Booking Holdings fully owns its brands.

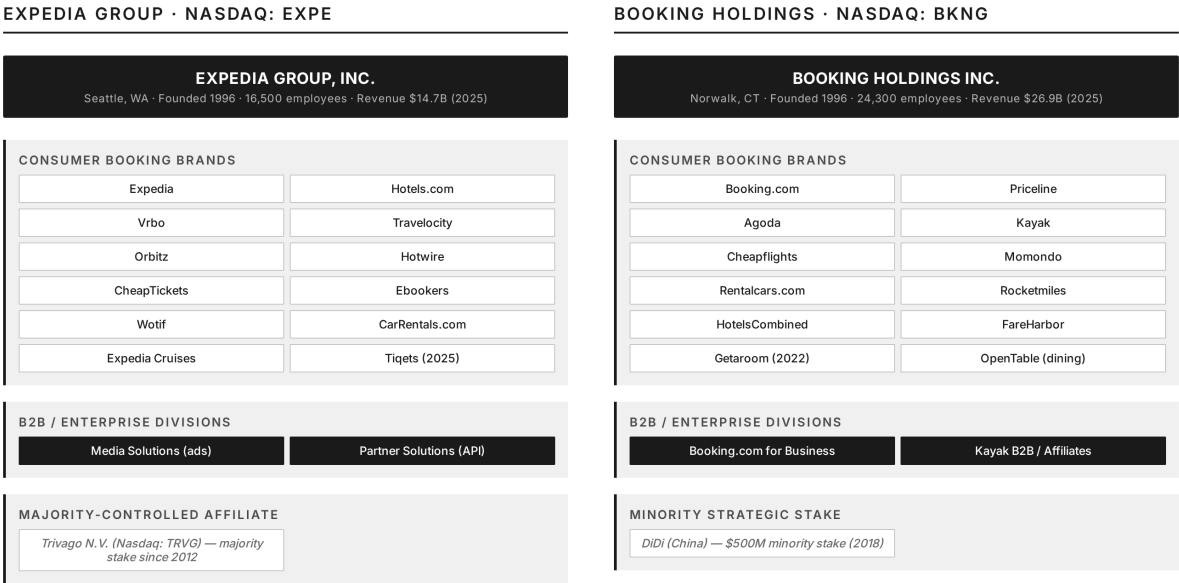


Figure 2. Corporate structure and brand portfolio of Expedia Group and Booking Holdings. Both parents wholly own their listed subsidiaries except where noted (Trivago is majority-controlled by Expedia; DiDi is a \$500M minority investment by Booking Holdings). Both giants share the same top-three institutional shareholders — Vanguard, BlackRock, and State Street — as a side-effect of passive index investing.

Direct Brand Match-Ups

The mirror-image structure is striking. For nearly every Expedia brand there is a Booking equivalent playing the same role in the market:



Legacy / discount OTA (US)	Travelocity / Orbitz	Priceline
Hotel specialist	Hotels.com	Booking.com (hotels)
Vacation rentals	Vrbo (HomeAway)	Booking.com (vacation rentals)
Asia-Pacific OTA	(via Wotif, AU/NZ)	Agoda
Metasearch engine	Trivago (majority stake)	Kayak
Car rentals	CarRentals.com	Rentalcars.com
Flights metasearch	(via Trivago flights)	Momondo + Cheapflights
Activities / experiences	Tiqets	FareHarbor
Restaurant reservations	(none)	OpenTable
Loyalty program	One Key (2023)	Genius
B2B advertising arm	Expedia Media Solutions	Booking.com for Partners
B2B API / white-label	Expedia Partner Solutions	Kayak B2B / Affiliates

Table 4. Brand-by-brand match-up across the two OTA giants.

Strategic Asymmetries

The two giants are not perfect mirrors. The most important asymmetries: **(1) Restaurant vertical** — Booking Holdings owns OpenTable, the dominant US restaurant reservation platform; Expedia has no equivalent, having exited restaurant-tech in 2014 with the LaFourchette / TheFork divestiture. **(2) Geographic mix** — Booking.com dominates Europe and Asia-Pacific, while Expedia retains stronger share in the U.S. and Australia (via Wotif). **(3) Vacation-rental model** — Expedia's Vrbo is whole-home-only and skews to family trips; Booking.com's vacation-rental inventory is integrated into the main OTA flow and is increasingly indistinguishable from hotel supply. **(4) Corporate ownership of metasearch** — Booking Holdings owns Kayak outright; Expedia controls Trivago via majority stake but does not own 100% of its equity, creating quarterly consolidation complexity. **(5) Loyalty architecture** — Expedia's One Key is genuinely cross-brand (Expedia, Hotels.com, Vrbo share one wallet); Booking Genius is Booking.com-only and does not extend to Priceline, Agoda, or Kayak.

CHAPTER 6 · IMPLICATIONS

What This Means for Travelers

The duopoly-and-parity structure has three direct consequences for anyone booking travel online. Understanding these mechanics is the only way to find genuine price differences — and even then, the savings are typically small.

Consequence 1: Cross-Brand Comparison Is Largely Wasted Effort

If you compare Orbitz vs. Expedia vs. Travelocity vs. CheapTickets for the same hotel on the same dates, you are comparing four Expedia Group brands against each other. The displayed room rate will be identical because the hotel is contractually required to display the same publicly available rate on every OTA it distributes through. Similarly, comparing Booking.com vs. Priceline vs. Agoda compares three Booking Holdings properties against each other — again, same price. The cross-brand price-shopping era ended when parity clauses became universal around 2010-2015. Today, real price differences exist primarily between the OTA price and the hotel's own direct price (where regulation permits), and between OTA list price and loyalty-program-discounted net price.

Consequence 2: The Real Comparison Is OTA vs. Hotel Direct

Where narrow parity applies (most of Europe, Australia, India), the only place a hotel can publicly undercut the OTA rate is on its own direct website. In the U.S. and UK, even this is contractually forbidden under wide parity — though enforcement is rare. The practical move for cost-conscious travelers is to search the OTA to identify the property, then check the hotel's own website directly for any "book direct" discount, member rate, or packaged perk (free breakfast, parking, late checkout). These direct-booking incentives do not violate parity because they are typically structured as value-adds rather than price reductions — and even when they are price reductions, they do not surface in metasearch engines, so the OTA cannot easily detect and punish them.

Consequence 3: Loyalty Lock-In Is the New Price Competition

Since direct price discounting is constrained by parity, the real competition between Booking and Expedia now happens inside their loyalty programs. Booking.com Genius members get 10-15% off after booking; Expedia One Key members earn OneKeyCash redeemable across the three Expedia brands. The effective price a traveler pays depends heavily on which loyalty ecosystem they are in. Over a two- to three-year booking horizon, the loyalty member can save 5-10% versus a non-member, but only by committing to one ecosystem — which the OTA structures to discourage cross-shopping. This is the modern form of the duopoly's competition: not on list price (parity prevents that), but on repeat-customer retention mechanics.

CHAPTER 7 · REFERENCES

Sources & References

All factual claims in this brief are drawn from publicly available sources, primarily Wikipedia (whose own sourcing chain traces to SEC 10-K filings and major news outlets), the SEC EDGAR database for shareholder filings, and industry-published analyses of rate parity and OTA market structure. Key sources:

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Expedia Group — Official brand portfolio page

<https://www.expediagroup.com/brands/>

Booking Holdings — Official corporate site

<https://www.bookingholdings.com/>

Note on shareholder percentages: The figures for Vanguard, BlackRock, State Street, and Diller's stake are approximate as of 2024-2025 SEC 13F filings and proxy statements. Institutional ownership shifts quarter-to-quarter and reflects passive index fund positions, not operational control.